Indigenous peasant struggles against imperialist mining and its antisystemic effects in the dynamics of capital accumulation in the XXI century

José Manuel Mejía Villena

1. Introduction

The magnitude of the accumulation by repression (Robinson 2020) displayed by imperialist mining was evidenced in the headshots inflicted by the military and police state forces to indigenous peasants in Cajamarca and Apurimac, at the northern and southern Andes of Peru. As the episodes of state violence against unarmed indigenous peasants showed, imperialist mining relies on the Peruvian armed forces, in the form of bullets and headshots, as means to guarantee the circulation of the productive capital invested in mining operations by Newmont Mining Company (U.S. based gold mining corporation) and MMG[1] (Chinese copper mining corporation).

Imperialist mining is a useful interpretation category for Latin American countries where indigenous peoples are oppressed and exploited by a core international mining bourgeoisie that uses the national state apparatus and the domestic bourgeoisie as its guardians. The political and military foundations of imperialist mining aren't hold only by those state apparatus located on the territories where the TCC currently extracts mineral commodities, but also by the threat of military occupation where mining would be guaranteed by the hegemonic capitalist state.

Despite these powerful structural conditions, antimining struggles in Cajamarca are blocking the expansion of Newmont's gold mining extractive frontier, challenging the intentions of U.S. fractions of the TCC's to prolongate the fourth systemic cycle of accumulation. In a similar way, MMG copper mining operations are challenged in the southern Peruvian Andes of Apurimac. By obstructing the production and circulation of copper, the capital accumulation circuit of the Chinese fraction of the TCC can't accomplish the conversion of their invested productive capital in mining into augmented money-capital. If the mineral commodities aren't sold in the market, the capital invested in extracting them cannot yield profits and return augmented once more (Marx 1909:89-94).

I argue that anti-mining campaigns[2] have antisystemic effects due to their obstructive performances of struggle (Mejía 2021:97-99), blocking the extension of the extractive mining

[1] "MMG's major shareholder is China Minmetals Corporation (CMC). Founded in 1950, CMC is one of China's major multinational state-owned enterprises" (MMG Company 2022a).

[2] Anti-mining and mining struggles escalated into broader contentious campaigns, *"as sets of interconnected events sharing similar claims"* (Diani y Kousis 2014:387). Anti-mining contentious campaigns conceptualization is a product of my research master thesis in political sociology: *"[t]he anti-mining struggle can be observed and traced in the trajectory defined by its constitutive events. In this sense, through the analysis of the catalog of contentious events (Koopmans y Rucht 2002; Tilly 2002; Wada 2004) of the Social Protest*

frontier and the circulation of the transnational capitalist class's (TCC)[3] productive capital. In contrast with miners' unions struggles in Peru against mining companies in the "long twentieth century", since the 2000's the indigenous peasantry assumed the role of challengers in mining contention claiming for the defense of water and land in Peru (but also in Ecuador, Colombia and Chile) as vital values for their social reproduction, and developing their consciousness as an antagonist class in front of the TCC's mining bourgeoise.

The following section will approach these indigenous peasant struggles against the international mining bourgeoisie by focusing on two key dimensions: imperialist mining as a political regime of militarized accumulation, and the resurgence of the indigenous peasantry as a class-for-itself formation challenging the rule of capital in the Andean Region. The third section will describe the antisystemic effects of anti-mining and mining struggles by blocking the expansion of the extractive mining frontier, and obstructing the circulation of the TCC's productive capital invested in large scale mining.

2. Background and literature review

As a consequence, stark state violence against indigenous peasants ensues. Lastly, the concluding section offers a summary of the main arguments presented. Most sociological works related to mining in the Andes and capital accumulation agree on the centrality of indigenous peasant struggles against the capitalist extraction of mineral commodities. However, those analyses rarely theorize beyond the extractivist topic. Indeed, the Marxist perspective hasn't been yet properly deployed as an encompassing critical theory touching upon the relation between mining struggles and capitalism. In fact, this important theoretical gap has been pointed out Veltmeyer (2019), Engels and Dietz (2017) and Lust (2016, 2019).

Database of Peru (Arce 2014a), the set of anti-mining contention campaigns developed in the Peru in the period 2001 - 2015. Defining anti-mining contention campaigns as those contentious events that add at least twenty (20) anti-mining protest [collective]actions, based on the consistency of their collective claims in opposition to extractive intervention of a particular mining investment project (Diani y Kousis 2014; Mejía y Aurazo 2015). Then, to trace the process of scale shift, the observation of campaigns of anti-mining contention was considered instead of the [social] protests or contentious collective actions –which count was considered in the statistical analysis of both Arellano Yanguas (2011) and Arce (2014b)–. This precision is critical [...] considering that contentious campaigns denote a type of contentious event in which there are greater possibilities of observing the process of scale shift. Given that political contention campaigns imply the articulation of contentious actions in relation to the claim of a common demand." (Mejía 2021:69-70).

[3] The TCC is "*a transnational capitalist class with its own strategic class consciousness*" (Arrighi y Silver 1999:13). Robinson (2020) go further in the development of theory about the implications of the emergence of the TCC, tracing its process of transnational class formation as the integration of the leading fractions of national capitalist classes across borders which "*interests lie in promoting global rather than national markets and circuits of accumulation, in competition with local and national capitalist groups whose fate is more closely bound up with their particular nation-states. This TCC is the hegemonic fraction of capital on a world scale. It is made up of the owners and managers of the giant transnational corporations, or TNCs, and the financial institutions that drive the global economy*" (Robinson 2020:11). The quantitative measure of the size of the TCC was advanced also by Phillips (2018). The conceptualization and identification of the TCC provide an effective instrument for theory and politics as an outcome of Marxist class analysis.

The conceptual relation between extractivist mining and capital accumulation results somewhat obvious yet highly precise (Ragin 2008; Ye et al. 2020). However, to adequately explore the causal relations between mining struggles and capital accumulation requires a considerable effort at theory building (Rohlfing 2012). It requires theorizing about the veins within the capitalist system, ones where we can trace the blood of indigenous and peasant peoples, and of their miner sons and grandsons, flooding the post-colonial condition (Samaddar 2018:20-23) within which the antimining class struggles unfold in the Andes of South America. Those veins are in formal subsumption[4], while in fact the core of the indigenous and water beings of the Andes have been oppressed by the pressures of the capitalist world-system of mineral commodities since the XVI century.

The circuit of capital is restless at making a huge and deep cut in the veins of the Pacha Mama (Mother Earth), inflicting massive open pits overflowing with indigenous blood, where mining tailings are thrown, destroying the ecosystems and mountains, polluting water, intoxicating the soil with cyanide and mercury. At the same time, capitalism leads to an unjust control over land and water sources, at the cost of assassinating local artisanal miners and indigenous peasants, clearing the way so that the most advanced transnational corporations (TNC) can extract highly profitable mining commodities.

2.1. Imperialist mining and the dynamics of capital accumulation

Mining as a method of militarized capital accumulation in “America” was at the core of European interstate competition for mobile capital since the sixteenth century (Arrighi 1994). The money-capital accumulated in Europe through the invasion and colonization of "America" -mainly exporting silver and gold- was financed by the international credit system already operating in Europe, and the profits obtained helped finance the world-system expansion of capitalist state-building processes (Arrighi 1994:13), as political organizations created to guarantee capital accumulation (Robinson 2020:12).

Since the sixteenth century, the material expansion of capitalism as a world-system has been through four systemic cycles of accumulation, holding their financial expansion phases mainly in Europe, until the XX century when the hegemonic transition from Britain to the U.S. was completed. Although the U.S. extractive bourgeoisie has laid the institutional and military bases of imperialist domination in Peru since the beginning of the 20th century, the neoliberal advance of globalization processes during the century’s last decades favored increasing foreign direct investments also from mining corporations based on China, Canada and Japan. This shows how the international mining bourgeoisie takes advantage of the institutional and military conditions established by the U.S. imperialist bourgeoisie to operate

[4] “It [capital as a universal category] also explains the dialectical relation between what Marx had called formal subsumption, that is where capital had subsumed the labour process as it found it, taken it over in the existing form, brought into being by other modes of production, and real subsumption where capital produces capital and the entire society functions towards producing relative surplus value made possible by a less personalised and less violent mode of value creation and extraction” (Samaddar 2018:vi).

in Peru, although with a still reduced share of gold mining but with a considerable expansion in copper mining. Indeed, imperialist mining is a political regime of militarized accumulation which employ state violence to protect the profits of the international mining bourgeoisie as a fraction of the TCC, and not only the U.S. mining companies.

The most compelling fact to grasp the magnitude of imperialist domination is the firm instrumentalization of the Peruvian state apparatus: central and subnational governments, ministries, armed forces, national police, judiciary, parliament, but also paramilitary forces[5], all working towards the protection and benefit of mining companies from the U.S., China, Canada, and Japan. One must bear in mind that historically imperialist domination in Peru has always coincided with the development of the mining industry, as one of the economic sectors favored by foreign extractive capital, and that the main role of this domination consists precisely in securing the political conditions for capitalist exploitation and accumulation.

Since the beginning of the 20th century, the mining industry in the Andes was under the almost exclusive control of the imperialist U.S. bourgeoise. Mining was one of the industries where capitalism developed more rapidly, especially in the Andes, where since 1895 monopolistic capital was directed towards large scale mining, oil production and agriculture. The mining bourgeoisie is an hegemonic fraction of the imperialist rule coalition in Peru (Mariátegui 1928:21; Quijano 1988:116-21), and one of the central nodes of the transnational capitalist class (TCC). Indeed, the mining struggles carried out by miners' unions were, since their genesis, *active principles* of anti-imperialist resistance in Peru.

The process of union formation and politicization of the emerging mining proletariat in the central highlands of Peru went through a process of increasing radicalization during most of the 20th century. The intensity and harshness of military repression applied against miners protests at the Peruvian central Andes, including the massacres of Malpaso (1930) and Cobriza (1971), reveal the severity of mining struggles. The radicalization of mining workers' protests converges with the formation of a vanguard of Peruvian proletariat in open confrontation with the imperialist U.S. mining bourgeoisie.

The magnitude of state violence against mining workers struggles ordered by the former Peruvian president Alan García in the final years of his first term imply the militarization of mines and the assassination and imprisonment of a whole cast of miner's leaderships. In 1989, Saul Cantoral, leader of the national workers mining federation "Federación Nacional de Mineros Metalúrgicos y Siderurgícos del Perú" (FNTMMSP), was killed by the Rodrigo Franco Task Force, a paramilitary organization commanded by the APRA party government headed by Alan García, which systematically and selectively assassinated "subversives" by request.

[5] In northern Peru, Piura and Cajamarca, the state even contemplates the operation of the paramilitary group Forza, which is in charge of offering private security to Minera Yanacocha-Newmont.

The Social Protests Database of Peru (BPSP)[6] shows that Peruvian mining conflicts between 1980 and 1989 left 1058 workers miners arrested, 16 dead and 64 injured. In the mid-90s, the mining workers movement agonized in hunger struggles and sacrifice marches[7] to the city of Lima, demanding payment of their unpaid salaries, given that the mines were suddenly militarized or locked out. Finally, the mining workers unions' movement was demobilized during the 90's neoliberal authoritarian regime of Fujimori -if not coopted earlier as the miner's unions of the Southern Peru Copper Corporation in Moquegua and Tacna-.

2.2. The resurgence of the Andean indigenous peasantry in the XXI century

Around ten million of indigenous peoples survived the destruction of their old civilizations during conquest, the world didn't fit anymore in their consciousness. But in their consciousness survives a myth or a myth still makes sense in their consciousness, it is the myth of the new indigenous, of the Yawar-Inti (Blood Sun) and the resurgence of the indigenous world by a revolutionary vendetta. In opposition to Arboleda's (2020) interpretation about the formation of indigenous "identity politics", I argue that indigenous revolutionary subjectivity is an historical formation in movement, developing as an antagonist peasant class in formal subsumption under capitalism since the XVI century.

Martín Arboleda states:

> *"Already in the 1990s, before so called "identity politics" gained prominence in international academic circles, Ecuadorian philosopher Bolívar Echeverria—a renowned theoretician of cultural syncretism and capitalist modernity in Latin America—was already puzzled by the self-defeating cultural essentialisms of emerging variants of Latin American indigenous politics. Pre-Hispanic cultures in the Americas, he argued, were undergirded by profoundly relational cosmologies and hence were unable to perceive the "Other" as independent alterity. The otherness they perceived in the Spanish colonizers was for them a mere variant of the sameness of their own collective self. The European mindset, on the other hand, always construed the cultural other in terms of radical alterity, as absolute negation of their own identity"* (Arboleda 2020:210).[8]

[6] The Social Protest Database of Peru (BPSP) (Arce 2014a) is a catalog of protest events (Tilly 2002) whose coverage includes the period 1980-2015, prepared from the review of the daily editions of three national newspapers: El Comercio, La Republic and Express. I had the opportunity to coordinate the update of the BPSP for the covering period 2016-2020 for the Professor Moises Arce (Tulane University).

[7] The marches of sacrifice (*marchas de sacrificio*) are a performance of contention innovated by mining workers unions between the final 80's and first years of the 90's and it denote the mobilization of the mining workers and their families from the mining camps in the highlands of Cerro de Pasco, Huancavelica, Ayacucho, to the capital city of Lima where they moved to live and fight in the streets for the payment of their non-paid cumulated salaries. As I state, this performance constitutes an innovative but poorly effective response to the militarization of mines, that disables workers strikes as an effective performance of struggles in the mines.

[8] The footnote refereed in the cited passage is: "For Echeverria, their inability to construe the European invader as a cultural other gave indigenous peoples in the Americas a military disadvantage. This rendered them

For Arboleda (2020) as for Bolívar Echevarria, the indigenous people couldn't understand the antagonism between them and the Spaniards. Their cosmology, they believe, didn't allow the indigenous to realize that they were being killed by a collective external and antagonist to their life or "collective self". We need definitely to understand that Bolívar Echevarria should not have ideologically omitted the work of the Peruvian anthropologist Luis E. Valcárcel, not to force an approximation to the work of José Carlos Mariátegui, who found an already in movement indigenous revolutionary subject when they were going to work in their politization, at the beginnings of the twentieth century. Fortunately, the work of Alberto Flores Galindo (2010), made justice to this issue tracing the myth of Yawar-Inti in emblematic indigenous and popular struggles of Peru's history.

As the new indigenous and cholo intellectuals create the prophets of this myth, indigenous socialism forged at the beginnings of the XX century as the convergence of the "cholo group" with the indigenous peasantry already organizing themselves for indigenous revolution. The work of Mariátegui, Mayer and Valcárcel in the organization and creation of indigenous socialism, found an indigenous reemergence myth already in operation. The revolution realizes as a vendetta for the new indigenous, their remnants, their sons and grandsons. Revolution as a movement was already in operation in the Andes when the Amautas headed by José Carlos Mariátegui initiate their work. As he wrote in the prologue of "Tempestad en los Andes" de Valcárcel (Valcárcel 1927):

> *"I remember the unexpected and impressive type of agitator that I found four years ago in the Puno Indian Ezequiel Urviola. This encounter was the biggest surprise that Peru reserved for me upon my return from Europe. Urviola represented the first spark of a fire to come. He was the revolutionary Indian, the socialist Indian. Tuberculous, hunchbacked, he succumbed after two years of tireless work. Today it doesn't matter that Urviola doesn't exist. It's enough that he existed. As Valcárcel says, today the mountains are pregnant with Spartacs"* (Mariátegui in the prologue to Valcárcel 1927:11).

As I will argue later, the history of indigenous class struggle definitely precedes socialism, but most importantly the indigenous peasantry has learned how to instrumentalize it. Further, at the first quart of the 20th century, the indigenous peasantry not only instrumentalizes socialism but also environmentalism (Mejía 2021) fixed with the conjuring of sentient entities as mountains, water and soil (de la Cadena 2020). The "cholo group" is a social stratum in formation that emerges from the mass of the indigenous peasantry servile or semi-servile, differentiated by the incorporation of elements from the Western-criollo culture. Yet, at the same time holding, preserving or recognizing their difference and their origins in the

incapable of reaching a tendency toward absolute hatred and obstinate will to nullify the other." (Arboleda 2020: 210).

indigenous culture and in the indigenous peasantry social structure, as the mass from which they detached by migration (Quijano 1980:63-65).

As de la Cadena (2005:18) emphasizes about the visionary work of José María Arguedas: *"[u]ltimately, Todas las Sangres proposed an alternative indigenous social movement, a critical ally of the modern left— yet with an a-modern hybrid logic of its own. Literacy and modern politics were important, yet they had to be selectively used and translated, rather than eradicating, indigenous ways"*. The hybridity in this sense is performative and not a reproduction of western modernization as acculturation, instead the cholos as indigenous descendants have been building a proper cultural logic which recognizes their indigenous origins and also appropriates modern western elements, as they do with environmental discourses in the anti-mining and mining struggles[9]. As the case of the anti-mining struggles of Cajamarca illustrate, the cholo and indigenous peasantry actualized their interpretation of mining from a class perspective fed by ecological discourses (Mejía 2021) and indigenous cosmopolitics (de la Cadena 2020) in the defense of water, land and life.

3. Anti-mining and mining struggles in the Andes as an anti-systemic movement

Anti-mining struggles have an anti-systemic effect on the TCC's circuit of extended capital accumulation. By blocking the expansion of the mining extractive frontier and obstructing the production of mining commodities, anti-mining struggles are challenging the circulation of the productive capital of the international mining bourgeoisie. Likewise, by obstructing the production and circulation of mining commodities, the capital accumulation circuit of the TCC can't accomplish the conversion of their productive capital into augmented money-capital. If the mineral commodities aren't sold in the international market, the TCC's capital invested in mining extraction can't return in the form of profits and increased capital.

Since the early years of the 20th century, mining investments in the Andes and Latin America were basically monopolized by the U.S. international mining bourgeoisie. Gradually, in the 21st century China's mining operations increased in Latin America since the imperialist domination couldn't exclude Chinese corporations from the mining industry in countries where U.S. imperialism[10] rules. The exception to China's mining transnational expansion in the Andes is the gold mining sector; with relevant implications for the dynamics of transition,

[9] The analysis of the Peruvian mining contention using protests event catalogs supports the need to distinguish two types of mining struggles: i) a subset that we assimilate to the anti-mining struggles characterized by radical ecological claims completely opposed to mining activities in a certain territory; and ii) the complement of that subset configured by mining protests aimed to achieving some type of compensation for mining pollution or also redistributing the benefits of mining, whether in the form of rents or in goods and services provided by mining companies. The miner's union struggles fit in this second subtype of mining contention, because their claims for better labor conditions and wages weren't in opposition to mining operations; as the anti-mining peasants' struggles of the 21st century.

[10] The imperialist domination is a constitutive feature of the accumulation regime of global capitalism which implies the political subordination of the domestic national bourgeoisie to the transnational capitalist class, and the disposition of a weak state built as a guard of their productive capital in territories under direct and indirect rule (Quijano 1979; Arrighi 1994).

hegemonic crisis, and regime of accumulation in the current critical juncture of global capitalism.

The total reserves of China in 2021 (3,43 trillion US$) are 4.79 times the volume of total reserves of U.S. for the same year (716,15 billion US$) (Fig.1). Although, the U.S. total gold reserves for the same last year 2021 was of 475,95 billion, and China's total gold reserves only ascend to 114,01 billion (0,114 trillion) (Fig.2). A long twentieth century of imperialism over gold mining countries apparently holds a current U.S. high advantage in monetary gold holdings, which imply a non-actually completed transition to China as a new hegemonic state of global capitalism. Antimining and mining struggles against U.S. gold mining and China copper mining in Peru evidenced a complex dynamic of imperialist mining from which approaches of U.S. hegemonic crisis and the initiation of a fifth systemic cycle of accumulation with "Chinese characteristics" can be problematized beyond.

In the actual critical juncture of capitalism's systemic chaos (Arrighi and Silver 1999), anti-mining struggles in the Andes and Latin America take an anti-imperialistic and anti-systemic role. To initiate a fifth systemic cycle of accumulation, the transnational capitalist class requires investing the enormous magnitude of money-capital already accumulated in the branches of industry where larger profits can be obtained. Until new industries or future technological innovations[11] could offer larger profits to the TCC, their productive capital will be located intensively in the branches of industry they know can provide larger profit returns, as mining. A new material expansion phase is a necessary condition for another cycle of financial expansion, but this time the extended accumulation circuit mechanism could be reaching its natural limits[12]. Not only climate change but also historical change constrains and obstructs capitalism reconstitution at the present.

Until the beginning of the Twenty First century, the rising tide of environmental struggles carried out by peasant mobilization against the imperialist mining bourgeoisie takes particular relevance to the development of class struggle in general. As an industry of larger profits, mining is monopolized by the TCC across colonial and imperialist mining periods, making mining a post-colonial element of the political economy of Andean societies. A feature of the indigenous peasantry class foundation is that it goes beyond coloniality and imperialism, where other elements of indigenous and cholo political syncretism flow in

[11] The process of mining capital accumulation is tied to the new main industries for capital enlarged reproduction, as the sector of computing and information technology (CIT), that makes technically possible the greater mobility and (financial) liquidity of capital at our time (Robinson 2020:34-35). Further research about the volume of mining commodity-capital selled to CIT companies for the production of technology for consumption, for the construction of means of production, and for military technology.

[12] ""Natural limits" posed obstacles to capitalist accumulation in the form of resource shortages, declining soil fertility and agricultural productivity, pollution, and so on, on the one hand, and environmental struggles against the exploitation of nature, which raised capital costs and reduced circulation time of capital, on the other" (O'Connor 1984:9, fn.17).

conjunction which new historical processes of class struggle, technological innovation and interstate competition for mobile capital.

Mining industry, taken as a large-profitable investment for capital accumulation by transnational capitalist class, exhibits clearly the other side of extended reproduction, the militarized dimension of capital accumulation actualizes today in the repression of indigenous peasants anti-mining struggles. In this sense, anti-mining struggles require study as a priority field of contention for class struggle development in the Andean region, considering their position in the mines of the capital accumulation circuit in a period in which financial capital requires another phase of material expansion. The realization of another cycle of capital accumulation -a more profitable one for capitalist reproduction- actually depends on their high profitable industries to take a big breath by the circulation of money capital into productive capital (MCM'). Indeed, anti-mining struggles grow as limits to capital accumulation and imperialist domination in the Andes, in Latin America and at a global scale.

O'Connor (1984) tried to remind to other radical thinkers in the middle of the 80's, that Marxist theorists *"left few clues regarding possible 'external barriers' to capitalist accumulation in the form of either 'limits to growth' determined by the availability of natural resources or [...] limits to accumulation determined by cultural-ideological conditions of economic and social reproduction"* (O'Connor 1984:6). Environmental socialist struggles, as he would also state, are a central field of contention *"to combat the attempt by capital and the state to ideologically construct and politically use the current crisis to restructure economic, political, and social life with the sole purpose of renewed capitalist accumulation, including a new 'long wave' of ideological innovation"* (O'Connor 1984:23). Nevertheless, the material challenge that environmental socialist struggles display over militarized accumulation, as in antimining struggles in the Andes, show a further development of the ideological struggles mentioned by James O'Connor.

3.1. Anti-mining struggles blocking the expansion of the U.S. gold mining extractive frontier in Cajamarca

The expansion of the extractive frontier of Minera Yanacocha-Newmont[13] in Cajamarca has been contested by an anti-mining movement that employs what is called a unique front[14]

[13] Minera Yanacocha-Newmont label in this document to Minera Yanacocha SRL. A mining company constituted by Newmont Mining Company (51.35%) and Compañía Minas Buenaventura (43.65%). The International Finance Corporation also owns 5% of the shares of Minera Yanacocha (Arce 2015:148-49; Bebbington et al. 2007:180; De Echave et al. 2009). By the end of the first decade of the 21st century, Minera Yanacocha had already extracted 19 million ounces of gold valued at approximately 7 billion dollars (Arce 2015:145) from the mines of Cajamarca.

[14] The united front strategy is pointed out by José Carlos Mariátegui as a solution to the problem of organizing the vanguard of the labor movement. Following the claim of unity of the proletariat and in favor of the development of its class consciousness, Mariátegui (1924) offers a basic vindictive program for the unity of the vanguard of the proletariat in formation, fragmented not only by productive specialization but also by differentiation, ideology and affiliations within the Peruvian popular movement at the beginning of the 20th century. The unique front is "a contingent, concrete, practical action", "a solidary [class] attitude in the face of

strategy. It has proven to be effective in creating sufficient people's social power to confront imperialist mining. The harshness of the military's repression against the popular and mainly peasant anti-mining movement in Cajamarca revealed the cruel side of the imperialist domination of Peru, just after the democratic election of a president of nationalist and military background. The anti-mining struggles in Cajamarca taught us that peasant struggles can be interpreted and developed as anti-imperialist struggles, since they imply a class confrontation between two extremes of capitalist accumulation: the international mining bourgeoisie and the indigenous peasantry. The challenge that anti-mining struggles represent for the central nucleus of imperialist domination in countries where mining constitutes the main enclave of capitalist accumulation, points to the strategic nature of the anti-mining struggles. They are the spearhead for the development of an anti-systemic movement, as well as critical for the geoeconomics needs of the dynamics of capital accumulation during the systemic crisis of the 21st century (Veltmeyer 2015:124; Wallerstein 2002:38).

The anti-mining struggles for the defense of Quilish mountain and the water sources of Cajamarca in 2004 had shown the effectiveness of the unique front strategy: they have joined the efforts of multiple organizations. These include: peasant nightwatch organizations[15] ("rondas campesinas"), irrigation boards ("juntas de riego"), urban nightwatch organizations ("rondas urbanas"), the teachers union at the provincial and district level (SUTEP-Cajamarca), fractions of the PCP-PR[16] of Cajamarca, and university students and environmental NGOs such as Ecovida and Grufides. Since the beginning of the struggle against the Conga mining project of Minera Yanacocha-Newmont in November 2011, the environmental defense fronts confronted the government of the recently elected president

a concrete problem, in the face of an urgent need" motivated by the class solidarity of those who are committed to the development of the popular movement, and in In this sense, they are aware of their historical duties and committed to the common, basic demands of the socialist program: "The class movement, among us, is still very incipient, very limited, for us to think about breaking it up and splitting it. Before the hour arrives, inevitable perhaps, of a division, it is up to us to carry out a lot of common work, a lot of solidarity work. We have to undertake many long journeys together. It is up to us, for example, to arouse in the majority of the Peruvian proletariat, class consciousness and class feeling. This task belongs equally to socialists and trade unionists, to communists and libertarians. We all have the duty to sow seeds of renewal and spread classist ideas. We all have the duty to distance the proletariat from the yellow assemblies and the false 'representative institutions'. We all have the duty to fight against the attacks and the reactionary repressions. We all have the duty to defend the platform, the press and the proletarian organization. We all have a duty to uphold the claims of the enslaved and oppressed indigenous race. In the fulfillment of these historical duties, of these elementary duties, our paths will meet and join, whatever our ultimate goal may be" (Mariátegui 1924).

[15] The peasant nightwatch organizations (rondas campesinas) were created, initially, to defend themselves against rustling. However, its success in the fight against common crime in the hamlets of Cajamarca progressed until it organized a popular justice administration system that spread successfully since the 1970s in northern Peru, becoming institutionalized during the 90's (Gitlitz 2013). Progressively, the effectiveness of the peasants nightwatch organizations administering justice on the margins of the Peruvian state led them to integrate into the dynamics of mining struggles in defense of land, water, life and dignity of the people of Cajamarca (Pérez Mundaca 2012). The translation of the category "rondas campesinas" as peasant nightwatch organizations was influenced by the English translation made by Orin Starn (1999).

[16] The abbreviation PCP PR denoted a further institutionalized secession of Peruvian Communist Party which adopts the PR "Patria Roja" denomination. Also see: Navarro (2010).

Ollanta Humala who had promised to the peasants that Cajamarca's lagoons would not be destroyed nor would mining be allowed without popular consent.

In this context, the sustained anti-mining campaign opposing Minera Yanacocha-Newmont's Conga project escalated, contesting not only to the U.S. gold mining company, but directly the administration and government of the former military captain and now President Ollanta Humala. The formation of the environmental defense fronts at the beginning of the first decade of the 2000s in Cajamarca was the result of a political coalition between the environmental NGOs –particularly Ecovida–, the teachers provincial union (SUTEP Cajamarca) and the peasant nightwatch organizations then controlled by the PCP-PR, as an effective strategy to unite the popular forces in defense of Cajamarca's water sources. However, after some time this coalition lost control of the popular anti-mining movement.

In this context, a new group of leaders, composed of radical professional politicians, garnered control of the movement, limiting the role of the PCP-PR and the environmental NGOs. Thus, in September of 2010, Celendin's first declaration was made to create the Interprovincial Coordinator for the Defense of the Environment, which forged a new strong coalition for anti-mining struggle including second-level organizations of five provinces located in the direct influence area of the Conga mining project (Interview LM2 03/06/2014). This coalition would allow coordination between the environmental NGOs, led by Marco Arana (GRUFIDES), and the radical fraction of the popular movement of Cajamarca led by Wilfredo Saavedra. As the latter was gaining strength among the peasant and urban bases of Cajamarca, bringing together fractions of the teacher's union (SUTEP Cajamarca) and peasant and urban nightwatch organizations ("rondas campesinas y urbanas") opposed to the control of the PCP-PR, the frictions between these sectors worsened.

With the formation of this new coalition, the sector of Wilfredo Saavedra would be in charge of learning and translating the environmental framework to a broader sector of the peasantry, university students and neighborhood organizations.[17] This demonstrated the capacity of the radical sector leadership to further broaden the bases of the unique front against the expansion of the extractive frontier of Minera Yanacocha-Newmont. The radicalization of the struggle began on November 24, 2011, when the peasants of Bambamarca and Celendín took over the lagoons that the Conga Mining Project planned to destroy. This performance of struggle required an effective organizational structure that would allow the mobilization and rotation of 200 peasants every two days to prevent the machinery of Minera Yanacocha, the police and the military from entering the lagoons and taking control (Interview LM5 03/08/2014).

[17] As the first arrangement made by the popular and peasant organizations to develop their struggle for the defense of water against Minera Yanacocha-Newmont, the promulgation of the Celendín declaration in November 2010 was supported by 36 delegates from grassroots organizations of five provinces of Cajamarca. Furthermore, for the declaration of San Pablo in 2011, the Interprovincial Coordinator for the Defense of the Environment had the support of 250 delegates (Interview LM5 03/08/2014).

The magnitude of the repression carried out by the government of Ollanta Humala crudely demonstrates the operation of mining accumulation by repression against the peasantry of Cajamarca. The militarization of Cajamarca was order by decree RS 231-2012-DE, which imposed the state of emergency from May 29 to June 25, 2012 in the provinces of Cajamarca, Celendín and Hualgayoc.

In this context, on July 3, 2012, during the 34th day of the regional strike ("paro regional indefinido") in Cajamarca, the military forces killed four peasants in the town's square of Celendín:

> *"Here, on July 3, it happened that the police and the military were down on the corner [..] when they started shooting at us, then the people who were here in the central square [of Celendín] began to run through different places […]; and the people […] took shelter here in the church of the Virgen del Carmen. And when the police and the military came […] wanting to break it down [the door] […]. The priests were inside […], the door of the church was open to shelter us because if it hadn't been open suddenly more of us would have been killed; but thank God the door was open, and we entered, more or less 200 people. We were sheltered inside from around 4[pm]in the afternoon until 8:30 at night, until the priest asked the Ombudsman of the Peruvian state to come and get us out: because we couldn't go out because the military and the police were full [at] [the courtyard of the church]. […] And then they thought that we had thrown stones at each other, we had killed each other with stones [referring to the fallacious and blatant lies of the then Minister of the Interior, who had "informed" that the [four] dead in Celendín were a result of stones thrown by the protesters themselves]. But it wasn't true because my son had the bullet that had entered his mouth. The first helicopter that came, then […] since he was filming the helicopter, like this [raises an arm and makes the gesture of holding a video camera or cell phone pointed at the sky] […] the bullet had entered through his mouth and had stayed […] in the brain. So that was what they had taken out [in the autopsy] because the little teeth here and the bones there [touches his mouth] had been found in his stomach"* (SERVINDI 2014).[18]

The mobilized groups in Celendín marched to the Municipality's building to demand the town Mayor Mauro Silas to stay on the people's side in their struggle to defend the lagoons. The shots made by the military from the balcony of the municipal building and from helicopters, exhibited the magnitude of the imperialist mining repression. The brutality of the military's repression of the popular anti-mining movement in Cajamarca revealed the imperialist nature of the domination exercised by the international mining bourgeoisie.

[18] Translated by the author.

3.2. Obstructing China's copper mining under imperialist U.S. domination in Apurímac

The cruelty of the imperialist repression against the mining workers during the 20th century reveals the magnitude of the repression of the anti-mining struggle carried out by the peasantry today, after a century of political mining contention in Peru. The social formation that currently directly confronts extractive mining capital is the peasantry, not the mining proletariat. By claiming the defense of water, land and life against the extension of the extractive frontier, anti-mining struggles show themselves to be absolutely antagonistic to the extractive capitalist accumulation process. That is, as a frontal struggle against the international mining bourgeoisie, and even beyond, the anti-mining struggle confronts the capitalist system and the productive and commercial dynamics that sustain it on a global scale, blocking its reproduction. Faced with this problem, imperialist domination mobilized the armed military forces to enforce the interests of the mining bourgeoisie (Lust 2016:5).

On Friday, October 14, 2016, two hundred indigenous peasants from the communities of Choquecca, Quehuira, Allahua, Antuyo and Pumamarca, located in the province of Cotabambas (Apurímac), began a road blockade obstructing the trucks loaded with mineral ore through the mining road used by the Chinese capital company MMG Limited Las Bambas. The peasant communities demanded payment from the mining company for the use of a communal road within their territories, through which the mine site connects to the main mining road and the trucks loaded with mineral ore head to the port of Matarani in the region of Arequipa. The road blockade that started that morning was brutally cleared by the police, killing community member Quintino Cereceda Huiza with a bullet to the head and wounding twenty more peasants. A few days later, the Minister of the Interior (security) Carlos Basombrío, declared that the police forces were not authorized in any way to clear the road blockade that day (El Comercio 2016:8).

The communities of southern Cotabambas rebelled against the power of the Chinese mining company MMG Limited Las Bambas for 186 days until April 17, 2017, when the province of Cotabambas was assigned the state of emergency, authorizing military repression against community members. Although the mining struggle of the peasant communities of Cotabambas (Apurímac) against the Chinese mining company MMG Limited Las Bambas[19] did not include an anti-mining claim -as in Cajamarca-, the magnitude of the repression executed to secure the interests of China's mining bourgeoisie confirms that imperialist mining is ruled by the TCC.

[19] "Las Bambas is a joint venture project between the operator MMG (62.5%), a wholly owned subsidiary of Guoxin International Investment Co. Ltd (22.5%) and CITIC Metal Co. Ltd (15.0%)" (MMG Company 2022b).

4. Conclusions

The article shows that anti-mining struggles have an anti-system effect on the TCC's circuit of extended capital accumulation, and effectively challenge imperialist domination in Peru. By blocking the expansion of mining's territorial frontier and obstructing the production and circulation of mining commodities, anti-mining struggles challenge the mining bourgeoisie and the circulation of its productive capital.

The effectiveness of obstructive anti-mining performances in Peru was revealed at least since 2004, with the success of the anti-mining protests against Minera Yanacocha-Newmont and the withdrawal of government authorization to explore the Quilish mountain in Cajamarca. The increasingly radical nature of the contentious performances by the peasants of Huambocancha Alta and Huambocancha Baja achieved an uninterrupted blockade of the access route to Minera Yanacocha-Newmont gold mine, and stalled the police forces sent to unblock it. Although it wasn't the first time that highway was blocked during episodes of anti-mining contention in Cajamarca, it is worth saying that such the blockade leads to the gradual stoppage of the mine's gold mining activities, significantly affecting its production and profits (Mejía 2021:97).

Ross (2003:54, 62) points out that minerals are a type of natural resource whose transport is relatively easy to obstruct, which has implications for the duration and intensity of extractive conflicts. The blockade implied not only the impossibility of access and exit to the mine's facilities, but also the expensive use of helicopters for the supply of fuel, equipment, labor and other supplies (Pérez Mundaca 2012:70-71). Thus, the obstructive performance blocking the Cajamarca-Bambamarca highway ended up drowning Minera Yanacocha-Newmont, proving to be as an effective measure of struggle for almost the entire duration of the anti-mining campaign for the defense of Quilish mountain (Mejía 2021:98-99).

Innovative obstructive performances shared in Apurímac and Cajamarca highlight the way in which imperialist mining operates in the Andes. The companies of the international mining bourgeoisie need to establish the flow of the extracted mineral either to a smelting plant - such as the Southern Peru Copper Corporation has in Moquegua -, or directly to the port of Matarani in Arequipa. As suggested by Ye et al. (2020:7), mining TNC claim the monopolized control of the territory and its resources, but also of the entry and exit points from which mineral commodities are transported to a port for exportation, finally traded for export, where it completes its conversion into money-capital. In this sense, anti-mining and mining struggles in the Andes effectively block the expansion of the extractive mining frontier and obstruct the circuit of the TCC's productive capital invested in mining. The indigenous peasantry is actually at the forefront of anti-systemic movements challenging the reproduction of global capitalism to defend their water, their lands, and their "collective self" from imperialist mining.

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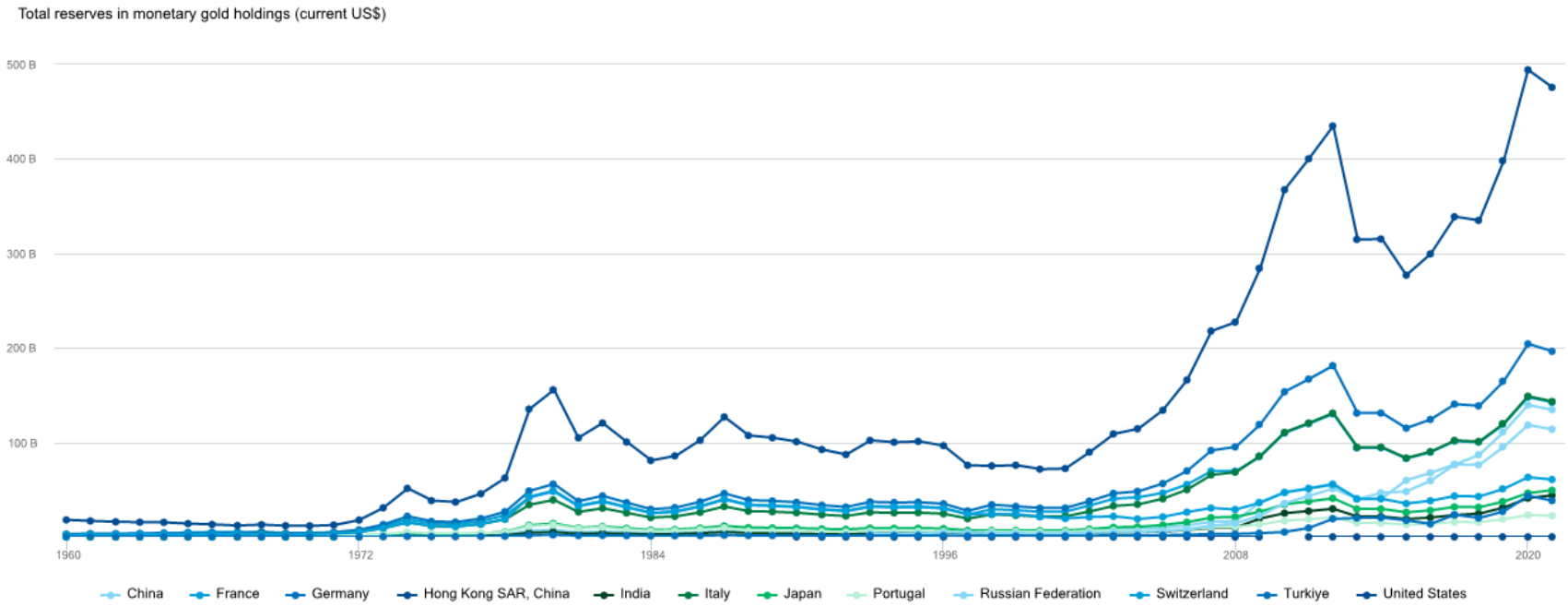
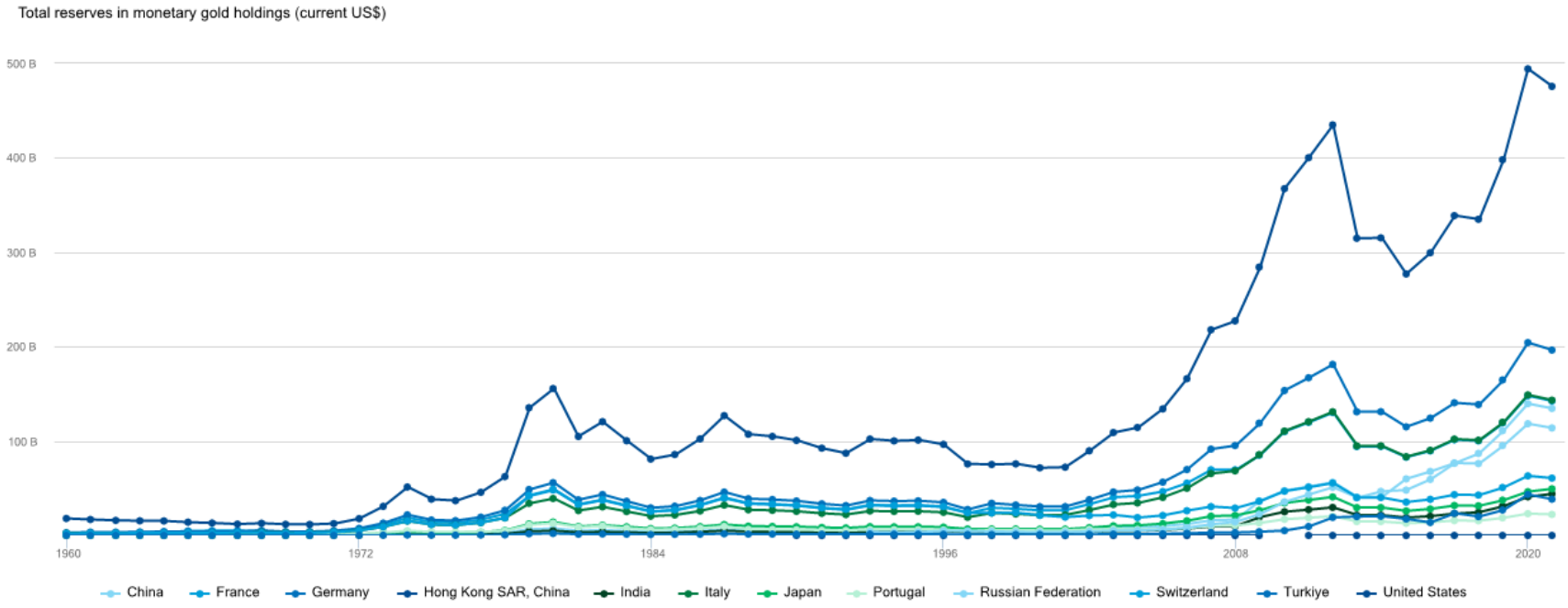
6. Figures

Figure 1. Total reserves include gold (current US$), 1960-2021



Total reserves in monetary gold holdings (current US$) is an indicator calculated by the author with the expression: Total reserves (includes gold, current US$) - Total reserves minus gold (current US$).
Series : Total reserves in monetary gold holdings (current US$)
Source: World Development Indicators
Created on: 11/22/2022

Figure 2. Total reserves in monetary gold holdings (current US$), 1960-2021



Total reserves in monetary gold holdings (current US$) is an indicator calculated by the author with the expression: Total reserves (includes gold, current US$) - Total reserves minus gold (current US$).
Series : Total reserves in monetary gold holdings (current US$)
Source: World Development Indicators
Created on: 11/22/2022